Given the grim situation, there was a grain of truth in that exchange. “The President was not optimistic, nor was I,” wrote Robert in his memoir. With two ExCom sessions in one day behind him, John Kennedy was getting ready to resume the meeting at 9:00 p.m. to continue discussion. Military confrontation and possibly all-out war were closer at that point than ever before. Discussion resumed as planned but led to no new policy decisions. Kennedy was playing for time. So were Rusk, Bundy, and other members of ExCom who knew of Robert’s secret approach to Dobrynin. The president was waiting for a response from Khrushchev both to his official letter and to his private proposal. He also had an alternative plan ready. On his instructions, Rusk had approached Andrew Cordier, an American diplomat who had served as U Thant’s special representative, with a request to persuade U Thant to propose the Cuba-Turkey swap. But first he had to hear the word from Moscow.[19]

Before going to bed that night, John Kennedy and Dave Powers entertained themselves by watching *Roman Holiday*, a 1953 romantic comedy with Gregory Peck and Audrey Hepburn. In the next room, if one believes her recollections, the nineteen-year-old Mimi Alford, a student at Wheaton College in Norton, Massachusetts, and one of Kennedy’s lovers, lay sleeping peacefully. Allegedly, Powers had brought her to the White House earlier that day, knowing of the president’s affinity for Mimi and deciding to take advantage of Mrs. Kennedy’s absence. No romantic encounter happened that evening—Kennedy was too concerned, remembered Mimi, about the prospects of war. “His mind was elsewhere,” she recalled. “His expression was grave. Normally, he would have put his presidential duties behind him, had a drink and done his best to light up the room and put everyone at ease. But not on this night. Even his quips had a halfhearted, funereal tone.”[20]

John Kennedy had a lot on his mind that night. He had at least two secrets to hide: his extramarital affair and his brother’s mission to Dobrynin. It was a desperate measure undertaken in secret from the full membership of ExCom. If rejected and made public by Khrushchev, the offer would not only endanger prospects for peace but also put Kennedy in an impossible political situation. The fate of the proposed secret deal would determine his future.